

PS3 Slim

Sony plans to price the 120-GB PS3 Slim around the same as the 80-GB PS3, but without any bundled games

XBOX 360

Microsoft has once again denied rumours it will release a Blu-ray drive for the XBOX 360

Blu-ray – The Indian Picture

We take a look at the Indian Blu-ray market and what it means for you

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We decided to go out to the market and take a look at the various options available to a consumer who wants to get onto the Blu-ray bandwagon. We went looking for both players that support this format as well as the availability of supported media at various locations.

Sony announced the Blu-ray format to the technology world in February 2002 with a lot of fanfare. The next generation format promised more storage space for playback of high definition video content and other storage purposes. However, by the time the standard was finalised and the first players were marketed in June 2006, the HD DVD format supported by the DVD Forum led by Toshiba had also launched competing players. With both sides having poured their fair share of time and money into the development of competing high definition formats, neither side was willing to back down. This led to the HD format wars. Blu-ray emerged as the victor in February 2008 with Toshiba finally withdrawing its support for the HD DVD format. With this, Sony could finally look forward to the broad adoption of Blu-ray by next generation devices.

Blu-ray vs. DVD

Compared to conventional DVDs, a Blu-ray disc of the same size can hold more data (50 GB vs. 9 GB for dual layer DVDs). While the resolution of DVD video is limited to 720x480

or 480p, Blu-ray video can go up to 1920x1080 or 1080p. Blu-ray discs also use better compression technology resulting in better picture quality. Availability of larger storage media, and high definition sound formats such as Dolby Digital True HD, result in superior audio quality. Blu-ray also has other enhancements such as picture in picture commentary, improved navigation menus and downloadable content. Most Blu-ray players also have the ability to upscale DVD content to improve its display quality for viewing on high definition TVs. All in all, Blu-ray is a definite improvement over regular DVDs.

Players

Since the second half of 2007, many companies have introduced Blu-ray players in India. Here, we only look at players

officially launched in the Indian market. Models that were not available in the market have not been listed below.

Philips: Two models available in India, the BDP3000 and the BDP7500 have 7.1 surround sound as well as DivX support in addition to standard features, the BDP7500 is a premium model with support for USB flash drives as well as the AVCHD camcorder codec enabling it to play videos directly. One issue with these players is that they are region locked (For more on region locks – see Box). Both these players are priced at approximately Rs. 16,000 – Rs. 17,000 and Rs. 24,000 – Rs. 25,000, respectively.

Panasonic: It's two models in India, the DMP-BD30 and the DMP-BD60 have AVCHD codec support and an SD card slot. In addition, the higher-end BD60 has a USB port and support for 7.1 surround sound. Both these players are region locked as well.

LG: The BD370 comes with DivX and USB support, but is region locked and has no support for 7.1 surround sound.

Sony: The BDP-S300 and the newer BDP-S350 have AVCHD codec support. The BD-S350 adds USB port and 7.1 HD sound decoding via HDMI. Both of them are approximately priced at Rs. 20,000 and Rs. 25,000.



Philips' BDP7500 supports USB flash drives, DivX with 7.1 surround sound output

DO YOU REALLY NEED BLU-RAY?

Even if you like to stay on the cutting edge of technology, you need to figure out if you'll get any benefit from buying a Blu-ray player.

Video

Many DVD players have an 'upscaling' option that improves the quality of SD (Standard Definition) content for display on high resolution LCD/Plasma TVs. Although not as good as actual high definition content, it does make a difference, and may appear fine to some.

To get the best out of a Blu-ray player, you should connect it to an HDTV with 1080 lines of progressive scanning, or 1080p. Usually, on TVs less than 40 inches or so, you will not be able to make out the improved quality provided by Blu-ray playback.

It's best to go to a showroom before making the purchase and check if you think it makes a significant difference to justify the expenditure.

Audio

Blu-ray discs also include high definition audio. However, you

need a player with compatible audio outputs as well as a capable home theatre speaker system to take advantage of the improved audio quality. A Blu-ray player supporting 7.1 surround sound is pretty useless if it's not paired with a 7.1 speaker system as well.

So to conclude: Yes, the Blu-ray format offers improved quality. However, if you are mixing it with older equipment or you're buying new equipment, take advantage of all the features in Blu-ray.